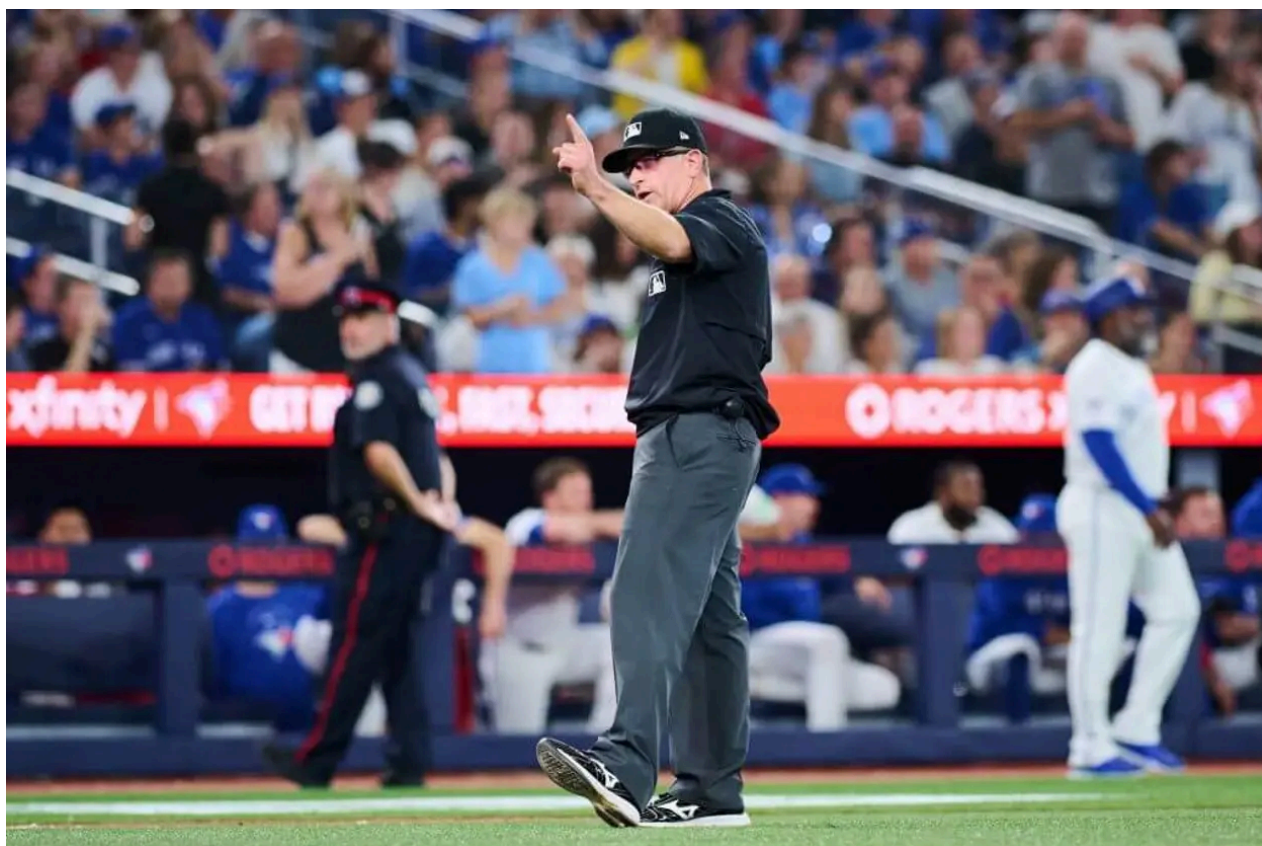


Red Sox-Blue Jays game delayed amid confusion over scoreboard, number of outs



Umpire Chris Guccione announced a rules check during a delay in the seventh inning of Monday's Red Sox-Blue Jays game. Sammy Kogan / The Canadian Press via AP



By **Mitch Bannon**

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TORONTO — The Toronto Blue Jays and Boston Red Sox game came to a halt halfway through the seventh inning on Monday, as the incorrect number of outs shown on the Rogers Centre scoreboard sent the game into chaos and the umpires into lengthy deliberation.

The situation resulted in a 15-plus-minute delay, Boston's first run of the contest and heavy booing from the home crowd. It ultimately didn't impact the game's outcome,

as Toronto won 2-1.

“It was strange,” Red Sox interim manager Chad Tracy, whose comments were posted by NESN, told reporters afterward. “We gotta know there’s one out, regardless of what’s on the board or not.”

After two Red Sox singles to start the top of the seventh, Nick Sogard sent a line drive to Vladimir Guerrero Jr. at first base. The Jays slugger dove for the ball, caught it on a bounce and fired a throw to second to get the first out. The play, however, was recorded as a double play on the stadium video board operated by MLB.

When, in the next at-bat, Boston's Ceddanne Rafaela flied out to center, the Red Sox runners on first and third broke on contact as if there were two outs. Jays outfielder Brett Bateman caught the ball, and Toronto relayed it in to get the third out at first base. The game then went into a long pause.

"What I was told was the rule is the rule," Toronto manager John Schneider said afterward. "It's a timing play, so if the run scores from third, no matter what he did, tagging up or not, before the out is recorded at first, the run counts."

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Amid the delay, Tracy and Schneider popped out of their respective dugouts. The umpire crew, led by crew chief Chris Guccione, met and talked with both managers.

"We are going to New York to do a rules check," Guccione announced to the stadium.

The home crowd booed, and then waited several more minutes before the umpires spoke again.

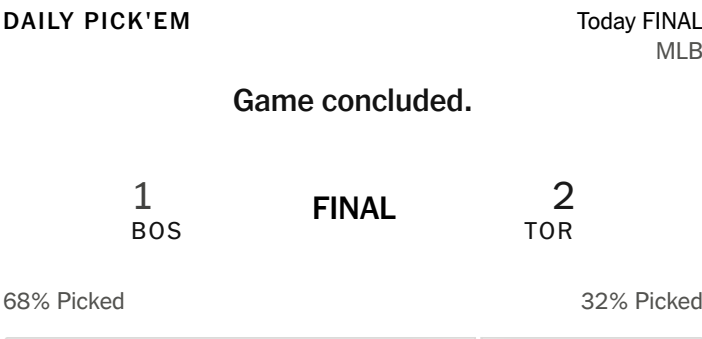
The crux of the confusion centered on MLB rule 5.09(c)(4), with respect to appeal plays. Since the Boston runner crossed home plate before the Jays recorded the third out at first, Toronto was required to appeal his early departure at third.

Thinking they'd recorded three outs and ended the inning, the Jays walked off the field and lost their right to appeal. They thought, Schneider said, the run had not counted because home plate umpire Charlie Ramos waved it off at the plate.

"After consulting with MLB," Schneider said, "(the umpires) told me that all of my players crossed the third base line before Charlie waved off the run, which I 100 percent disagree with. I don't know if Vlad is that fast after he got the ball at first."

The fact that the scoreboard was incorrect, Guccione told a pool reporter after the game, does not play a part in the ruling.

"That's just kind of a courtesy for the fans and for everybody," Guccione said. "It's our responsibility, as umpires, to understand how many outs there are."



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Schneider attempted to play the game under protest, believing that the Red Sox had to appeal the timing play at the plate, but teams are no longer able to play under protest after a 2020 rule change.

Eventually, Guccione turned back on his stadium microphone and announced the run would count, leading to further boos.

The game finally resumed, with Toronto leading 2-1. While Boston got the tying runner to third base in the ninth, Jays closer Louis Varland finished off the game to secure the win.

“When that play happens again in the next 100 years, if it’s us, we will record the lead out at third,” Schneider said.

Mitch Bannon is a staff writer for The Athletic covering the Toronto Blue Jays. Before joining The Athletic, he covered the Blue Jays for SI.com and wrote for MLB.com in a freelance capacity. He is a graduate of McGill University and the S.I. Newhouse School of Public Communications at Syracuse University.

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